



Preventing Food Poisoning

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For Everyone

AT A GLANCE

- Some foods are more likely than others to contain germs that can make you sick.
- To prevent food poisoning, follow the four steps to food safety: Clean, Separate, Cook, and Chill. Keep hands and surfaces clean, keep risky foods separate from other foods, cook food properly, and refrigerate promptly.
- If a food is recalled, throw it away.



Overview

Some foods are more likely to contain germs that can make people sick. These risky foods can spread germs to you, surfaces in your home, and other foods and cause food poisoning.

Know which foods are riskier and take simple steps to reduce your risk of food poisoning.

Riskier foods

Some foods are more likely to contain harmful germs, including:

- Raw or undercooked [poultry](#), meat, seafood, or eggs
- Raw or undercooked sprouts
- Unwashed fruits and vegetables
- Cut melon
- Unpasteurized [milk](#), juice, cider, or soft cheese
- [Raw dough or raw batter](#) made with uncooked flour

KEEP READING
[Safer Food Choices](#)

Prevention steps and strategies

Follow the four main steps to food safety: clean, separate, cook, and chill.

Wash your hands and surfaces often

Germs that cause food poisoning can survive in many places and spread around your kitchen.

- [Wash your hands](#) before, during, and after preparing food and before eating. Wash for at least 20 seconds with soap and warm or cold water.
- Wash utensils, cutting boards, and countertops with hot, soapy water after preparing each food item.

- Rinse fresh fruits and vegetables under running water.

Reminder

Always wash hands after handling uncooked meat, chicken and other poultry, seafood, flour, or eggs.



Separate foods to avoid cross-contamination

Raw meat, chicken and other poultry, seafood, and eggs can spread germs to ready-to-eat food unless you keep them separate. The table below shows how to keep risky foods from cross-contaminating other foods.

When grocery shopping	Keep raw meat, poultry, seafood, and their juices away from other foods.
When storing food	Keep raw or marinating meat, poultry, seafood, and eggs separate from all other foods. Store raw meat, poultry, and seafood in sealed containers or wrap them securely so the juices don't leak onto other foods.
When preparing food	Use one cutting board or plate for raw meat, poultry, and seafood and a separate cutting board or plate for produce, bread, and other foods that won't be cooked.

Keep in mind

- Raw chicken is ready to cook and doesn't need to be washed first. Washing these foods can spread germs to other foods, the sink, and the counter and make you sick.
- If you choose to wash chicken, do so as safely as possible ([see steps](#)).



Cook to the right temperature

Food is safely cooked when the internal temperature gets high enough to kill germs that can make you sick.

The only way to tell if food is safely cooked is to use a food thermometer. You can't tell if food is safely cooked by checking its color and texture (except for seafood).

Use a food thermometer to ensure foods are cooked to a safe internal temperature. Learn how to [place the thermometer correctly](#) in different food to get an accurate reading.

Safe internal temperatures for different foods

Whole cuts of beef, veal, lamb, and pork, including fresh ham	145°F (then allow the meat to rest for 3 minutes before carving or eating)
Fish with fins	145°F or cook until the flesh is opaque and separates easily with a fork
Ground meats, such as beef and pork	160°F
All poultry, including ground chicken and turkey	165°F
Leftovers and casseroles	165°F

Resource

Check this chart for a [detailed list of temperatures and foods](#), including shellfish and precooked ham.



Microwave food thoroughly

Follow recommended cooking and standing times. Letting food sit for a few minutes after microwaving allows cold spots to absorb heat from hotter areas and cook more completely.

- Know your [microwave's wattage](#). Check inside the door, owner's manual, or manufacturer's website. If your microwave is high wattage (800 watts or more), use the minimum cooking time recommended. If it is low wattage (300–500 watts), use the maximum cooking time recommended.
- When reheating, use a food thermometer to make sure that microwaved food reaches 165°F.

Refrigerate food promptly

Bacteria can multiply rapidly if left at room temperature or in the "Danger Zone" between 40°F and 140°F.

Never leave perishable food out for more than 2 hours (or 1 hour if exposed to temperatures above 90°F).

Keep your refrigerator cold

Keep your refrigerator at 40°F or below and your freezer at 0°F or below, and know when to [throw food out before it spoils](#). If your refrigerator doesn't have a built-in thermometer, keep an appliance thermometer inside it to check the temperature.

Storing food in the refrigerator

Package warm or hot food into several clean, shallow containers and then refrigerate. It is okay to put small portions of hot food in the refrigerator since they will chill faster.

Refrigerate perishable food (meat, seafood, dairy, cut fruit, some vegetables, and cooked leftovers) within 2 hours. If the food is exposed to temperatures above 90°F, like a hot car or picnic, refrigerate it within 1 hour.

Thaw food properly

Thaw frozen food safely in the refrigerator, in [cold water](#), or in the microwave. Never thaw food on the counter because bacteria multiply quickly in the parts of the food that reach room temperature.

Recalled food

Throw away recalled foods and [clean your refrigerator](#) if you stored a recalled food there.

Food Safety

News

[Midwest Poultry Services, L.P. Recalls Shell Eggs Due to Possible Salmonella Enteritidis Contamination](#)

Midwest Poultry Services, L.P. is voluntarily recalling 1,589,577 dozen white shell eggs and brown cage free shell eggs produced in Texas because they have the potential to be contaminated with Salmonella Enteritidis. Salmonella is an organism which can cause serious and sometimes fatal infections i

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[PT Organics Limited Recalls Select Pumpkin Tree Peter Rabbit Organics Banana & Strawberry Fruit Puree Pouches Due to the Potential for Soft Plastic to Enter the Finished Product](#)

July 21st, 2026, PT Organics Limited of Lake Oswego, Oregon is

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Resources

Find educational materials for print, web, and social media:



Educational Materials and Videos

Collection of social media, videos, infographics, and other resources related to food safety.

SOURCES

CONTENT SOURCE:
[National Center for Emerging and Zoonotic Infectious Diseases \(NCEZID\)](#)